> “I would sit for hours beside the window and look down at Earth with nothing coming to my mind—no thoughts, no worries, no questions. You are just observing what is happening and you don’t need anything. It is meditation in a way that is so easy. Time ceases”

the station had become your friends and it was hard saying goodbye to them. But this is a mission with a plan that has to be executed. And so, there was a slight moment where it was difficult saying goodbye and come back to Earth. But then when you get into the Crew Dragon capsule, you move on.

Q. On your return, as you re-enter Earth’s atmosphere, the friction causes the spacecraft to look like a great fireball. Was that exciting to see? There are also high risks of disintegration. Were you anxious?





BETWEEN EARTH AND INFINITY Left, the Ax-4 crew before beginning their return journey, Jul. 14; Shubhanshu in a reflective mood aboard the ISS

happening here. I didn’t know it had become such a huge deal in India, and that people were celebrating this mission, until my wife told me.

Q. Now let’s come to when your journey was done. Did you want to return to Earth?

I admit that, at first, I did not want to come back so quickly. You get comfortable in space and, after some time, it is fun. You are doing cutting-edge science designed by the best of researchers. And I was fortunate to be representing my country at the ISS and acting as a bridge between researchers and orbit and doing the science for them, doing stem cell experiments, understanding how physical processes of phenomena change due to the absence of gravity, looking back at Earth and capturing pictures. It was phenomenal. Having said that, obviously, there are challenges. There is a huge ecosystem on Earth—your friends, families and everybody who is missing you. At the same time, the people who were there on

No. I think there is a fine line between being excited and being anxious. You can choose. Either way, you don’t have control over the outcome, so it’s up to you to choose how you feel. Initially, the trip was smooth till we reached Earth’s atmosphere. Then, we were really excited to look at the blazing fire from our windows as we re-entered. To see all sorts of colours—orange, blue, purple, red. The temperature inside the capsule also rises by about six to seven degrees. Because you’re lying down in the spacecraft, you have to raise your neck to look at the windows and see the fireball around. And I remember feeling a big strain on my neck, a big load. When you were in microgravity, nothing was heavy and you could do anything you wanted. But now, suddenly, I started feeling very heavy. I looked at my display and it was showing 3G force. The shift that happens is so drastic that even the smallest of loads feels very heavy. Then, the fire suddenly stops, and you are in